



Kindergarten Learning Progression Toolkit

Executive Function Fact Sheet

Supporting reconciliation

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the Traditional Owners of the lands, seas, skies and waterways from across Queensland.

We pay our respect to the Elders past and present, for they hold the memories, traditions, the culture and hopes of Aboriginal peoples and Torres Strait Islander peoples.

A better understanding and respect for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures develops an enriched appreciation of Australia's cultural heritage and can lead to reconciliation.

This is essential to the maturity of Australia as a nation and fundamental to the development of an Australian identity.

Produced by:

Department of Education, Queensland

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Executive Function

Executive function is a set of skills that help children manage impulses, stay focused and work towards goals. These skills support learning and development across all areas and are shaped by each child's cultural, social and emotional experiences.

Families are children's first teachers, so executive function skills are influenced by family routines, relationships and community values. Recognising the whole child means seeing these relationships as central to their learning, wellbeing and identity. For Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children, awareness of their kinship networks and connections to Country are important to developing identity, which supports growth in executive function skills.

Children begin developing executive function in early childhood. It includes three key skills:

- **Working memory** makes it possible to keep information in mind, such as remembering instructions long enough to carry them out.
- **Inhibitory control** supports the ability to pause before acting and choose a suitable response.
- **Cognitive flexibility** enables attention to shift and adapt from one task to another.

Executive function skills are difficult to observe because they are internal cognitive processes. Teachers and educators can see executive function in action through observable behaviours like persistence, adaptability and problem solving.

Persistence: staying on task, trying again after challenges and completing activities.

Adaptability: adjusting when routines change, responding to new information and staying calm under uncertainty.

Problem solving: exploring ideas, testing strategies and reflecting on what works.

These behaviours draw on different aspects of executive function, for example, persistence involves inhibitory control, adaptability reflects cognitive flexibility and problem-solving uses working memory.

Feeling valued, successful and accepted enables all children to try new things, express themselves, work through differences and take calculated risks (EYLF V.2.0, 2022, p.32).



Persistence

Persistence is a child's ability to keep trying even when something feels hard or unfamiliar. You might observe children increasingly:

- stick with both preferred and non-preferred tasks
- stay focused despite distractions or challenges
- show determination in social, emotional and learning situations.

Adaptability

Adaptability is a child's ability to adjust their response when circumstances change. You might observe children increasingly:

- take in new information and make decisions in response
- respond calmly and stay open when routines or expectations change
- use social and emotional skills, such as self-regulation, alongside flexible thinking.

Problem solving

Problem solving is a child's ability to explore ideas, test them out and find solutions. You might observe children increasingly:

- break tasks into smaller steps and think through each part
- use what they already know to try out new ideas
- reflect on what works and adapt their approach as needed.

Teachers and educators play a key role in creating culturally safe and responsive environments that support children to grow these skills in ways that reflect their identities, strengths and ways of knowing, being and doing.

Educators can support executive function by:

- embedding a play-based approach to learning experiences
- encouraging persistence and scaffolding problem-solving
- helping children adapt to changes with flexible routines
- gradually increasing challenges while offering support and encouragement
- celebrating wins and supporting children in their losses.

Every child brings unique strengths to their executive function journey. By supporting diverse ways of learning, moving, and communicating, as well as cultural and linguistic identities, teachers and educators help all children thrive.

Supporting resources

Find out more about supporting children's executive function:

- [Foundations for Success](#)
- [Early Years Learning Framework](#)
- [Queensland kindergarten learning guideline](#)
- [National Quality Standard](#)
- [BELONGING, BEING & BECOMING: Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives](#)

NQS links: Quality Areas 1, 5 and 6

QKLG (2024) links: Identity, wellbeing and active learning